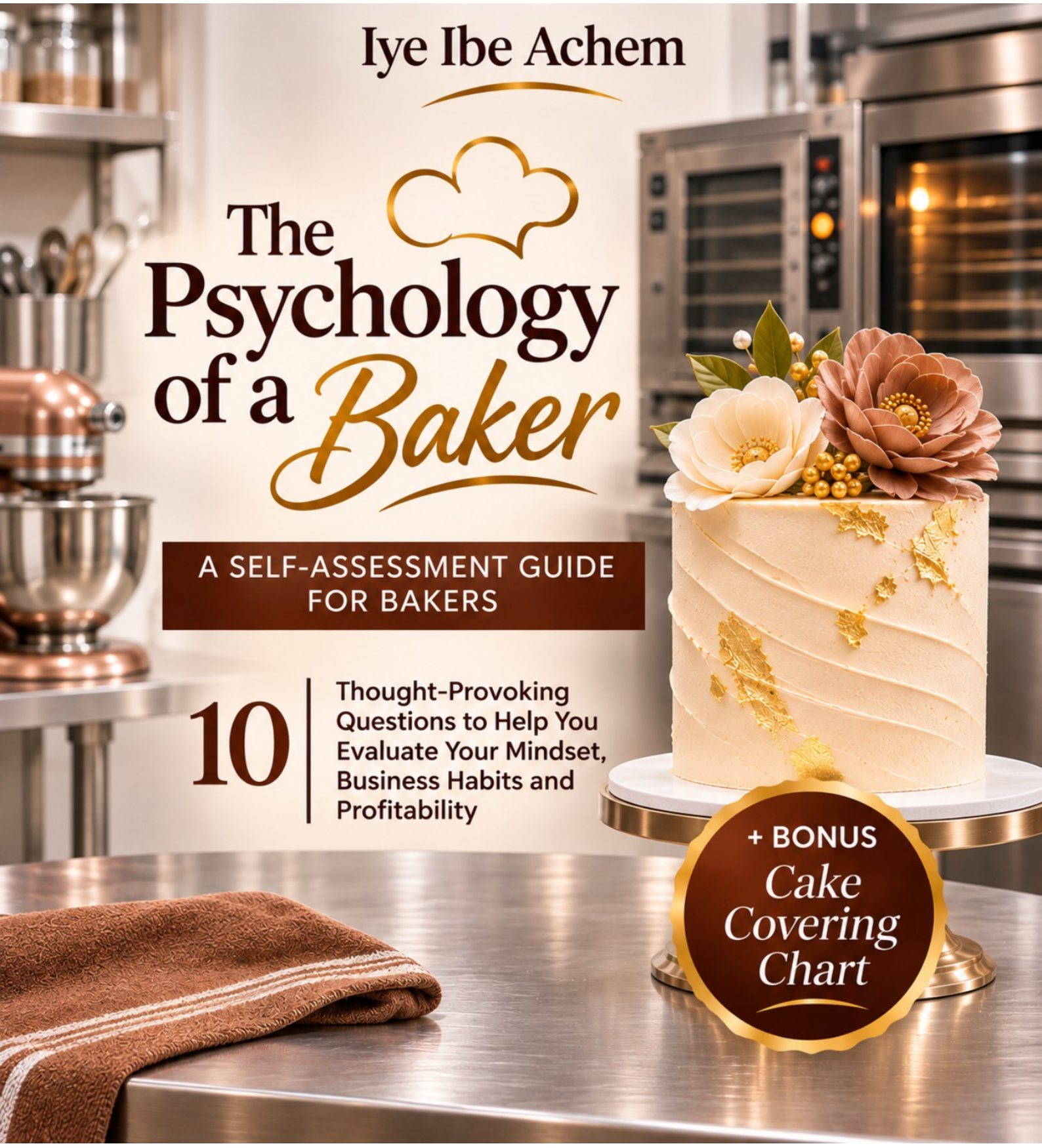

Iye Ibe Achem
The Psychology of a Baker
A SELF-ASSESSMENT GUIDE FOR BAKERS
10
Thought-Provoking Questions to Help You Evaluate Your Mindset, Business Habits and Profitability
+ BONUS
Cake Covering Chart

THE PSYCHOLOGY OF A BAKER

Ten questions about the money side of your cakes. Most bakers score three.

How to use it. Tick one box for each question. Answer the way things actually are in your kitchen, not the way you would like them to be. Nobody sees this but you, and a score that flatters you is no use to anybody. It takes about five minutes. Score yourself on page 3.

THE TEN QUESTIONS

1. What does one 8 inch chocolate cake cost you in ingredients?

- **a** I know it within ₦2,000 ☐
- **b** A rough idea, maybe ₦5,000 out ☐
- **c** I would be guessing ☐

2. What is one hour of your kitchen worth, once rent, light, gas, wages and your own pay are counted?

- **a** I know the figure ☐
- **b** I have never worked it out ☐
- **c** I do not charge for my time at all ☐

3. Do you pay yourself a salary from the business?

- **a** Yes, a set amount every month ☐
- **b** I take money when I need it ☐
- **c** No, whatever is left over is mine ☐

4. The last time you raised your prices, why did you?

- **a** My costs went up and I recalculated ☐
- **b** I felt I could get away with a bit more ☐
- **c** I have not raised prices in over a year ☐

5. Which of the things you sell earns you the most per hour of your time?

- **a** I know, I have compared them ☐
- **b** The big cakes, surely ☐
- **c** No idea ☐

6. If flour went up 20% tomorrow, how many of your prices would change this week?

- **a** All of them. I would recalculate ☐
- **b** A few, the ones that felt wrong ☐
- **c** None. I would absorb it ☐

7. What share of your price is ingredients?

- **a** I know the percentage
- **b** Around a third, I think
- **c** Never thought about it

8. How do you price a cake you have never made before?

- **a** I cost it properly before I quote
- **b** I look at something similar and add a bit
- **c** I say a number and hope

9. A customer says your price is too high. What do you do?

- **a** Explain what is in the price, and hold it
- **b** Offer a smaller size or simpler design
- **c** Drop the price to keep the order

10. Do you know whether you made a profit last month?

- **a** Yes, I have the figure
- **b** I think so. Money came in
- **c** No

SCORE YOURSELF

Give yourself **1** for every **a**, **a half** for every **b**, and **nothing** for every **c**. Add them up. Ten is the most you can score.

Number of **a** answers		× 1 =	
Number of **b** answers		× ½ =	
Number of **c** answers		× 0 =	0
YOUR SCORE OUT OF 10			

WHAT YOUR SCORE MEANS

Score	Where that puts you
8½ to 10	**You are in the small minority** Most bakers cannot answer half of these. You can. The gaps that are left are worth closing, because they are the expensive ones.
6 to 8	**You know more than most, and it is not enough** The parts you have covered are real. The parts you have not are where the money goes, quietly, every month.
3½ to 5½	**You are running on feel** This is where most Nigerian bakers sit. It is not carelessness, nobody ever showed you the arithmetic. But feel cannot tell you which orders are losing money.
0 to 3	**You cannot tell whether you are making money** That is uncomfortable to read and it is worth reading. Nothing here says you are a bad baker. It says you are flying blind on the money, and that is fixable in an afternoon.

WHAT TO DO ABOUT EACH ONE

Anything you did not answer **a** is a gap. Here is how to close it. You can do every one of these by hand. It is the doing it again on every cake, every month, that nobody has time for.

#	What to do
1	Weigh one batch. Divide what you paid for each ingredient by its pack size, multiply by what actually went into the bowl. One afternoon, and you never guess again.
2	Add up every monthly cost including your own pay, multiply by twelve, divide by the hours you genuinely produce in a year. Not the hours the shop is open.
3	Put yourself on the payroll at a figure the business can carry today, even a small one. Then your labour shows up in every price instead of vanishing.
4	Reprice when an ingredient moves more than 10%, not when you feel brave enough. Check it the first week of every month and it stops being a decision.
5	Cost your five best sellers once, then divide each one's profit by the hours it takes you. Rank them. The order will surprise you.
6	If one ingredient price can move all your prices in an afternoon, you have a costing system. If it cannot, you have a price list.
7	Work out ingredients as a percentage of your price on three recent orders. If the three are far apart, your pricing is not a method, it is a mood.
8	Cost it before you quote it, even roughly. Twenty minutes with a scale beats a number you cannot defend when she asks why.
9	Decide your floor before the conversation, not during it. Then you can offer a smaller cake instead of a smaller margin.
10	One page a month: money in, ingredients out, fixed costs out. Until that page exists, nothing else on this list can be checked.

YOU LOVE BAKING. BUT ARE YOU MAKING MONEY FROM IT?

You have just answered ten questions about the money side of your cakes. Some of them you could answer straight away. Others you had to think about, or guess at.

That is the point of them. Every one of those questions is sitting behind a price you have already quoted this year. What a cake costs you in ingredients. What an hour in your kitchen is worth. Whether you are on your own payroll. What you do when a customer says it is too much. Whether you could say, right now, if last month made money.

Your time, your labour, electricity, gas, decoration, packaging and the cost of simply keeping the place open all go into every cake you sell. When those are not counted, you can be busy, taking orders and posting cakes you are proud of, and still not making the profit your business needs.

The problem may not be that you are not selling enough cakes. It may be that you are not costing them properly.

But you can change that.

MEET THE CAKE COSTING SYSTEM

A practical costing and pricing tool that works out the true cost of producing your cakes, accounts for your business expenses, prepares accurate quotations, and shows you which of the things you sell are actually making you money.

Imagine knowing what a cake costs you before you decide what to charge. Imagine sending a quotation without second-guessing it, or wondering what you have forgotten. Imagine a customer telling you it is too expensive, and holding your price, because you can account for every naira in it.

You do not have to keep guessing. You need a better system.

Your baking business deserves more than beautiful cakes and impressive sales. It deserves to make money.

Take the next step towards costing with clarity and pricing with confidence.

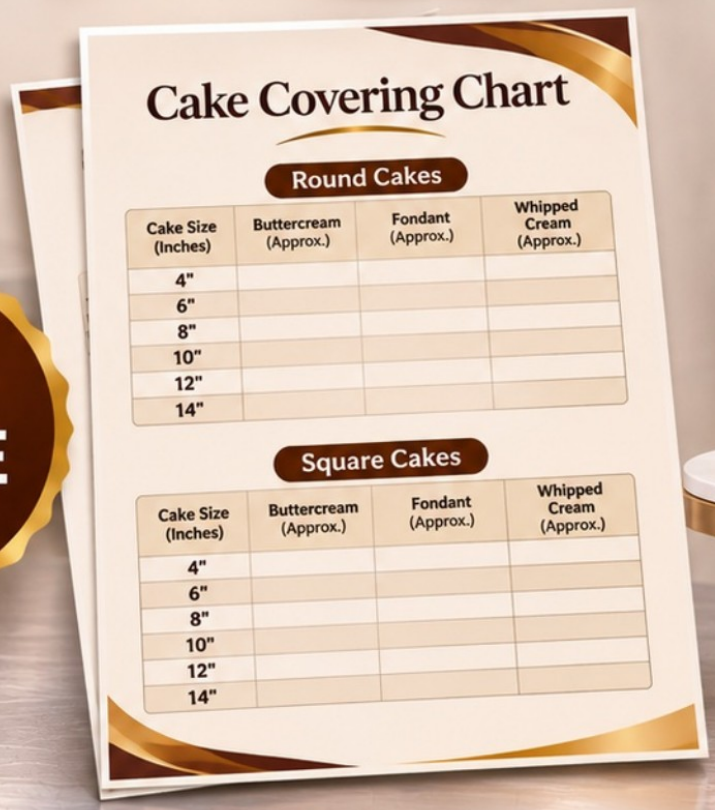
selar.com/cakecostingsystem

There are more free tools waiting for you on the website: a cake cost check, a recipe scaler, pan size equivalents and a weight to volume converter.
bakewealthinternational.com

Iye Ibe Achem

Cake Covering *Chart*

Your quick reference guide for cake finishing



Cake Covering Chart

Round Cakes

Cake Size (Inches)	Buttercream (Approx.)	Fondant (Approx.)	Whipped Cream (Approx.)
4"			
6"			
8"			
10"			
12"			
14"			

Square Cakes

Cake Size (Inches)	Buttercream (Approx.)	Fondant (Approx.)	Whipped Cream (Approx.)
4"			
6"			
8"			
10"			
12"			
14"			

FREE GUIDE

Estimate quantities. Cost your cakes with confidence.

CAKE COVERING CHART

How much buttercream, fondant or whipped cream one tier takes, filling and covering together.

Grams to **make**, not grams that end up on the cake: waste and trim are counted. **Buttercream and whipped cream include the filling between the layers as well as the covering.** Fondant is the covering only, since nobody fills a cake with it.

ROUND CAKES

	4 INCHES TALL			6 INCHES TALL		
Size	Buttercream 4 mm	Fondant 4 mm	Whipped cream 4 mm	Buttercream 4 mm	Fondant 4 mm	Whipped cream 4 mm
4″	200 g	440 g	100 g	300 g	610 g	150 g
6″	360 g	720 g	180 g	530 g	990 g	270 g
8″	530 g	1,050 g	270 g	810 g	1,400 g	400 g
10″	760 g	1,420 g	380 g	1,130 g	1,860 g	570 g
12″	1,000 g	1,840 g	500 g	1,510 g	2,360 g	760 g
14″	1,290 g	2,300 g	650 g	1,940 g	2,910 g	970 g

SQUARE CAKES

	4 INCHES TALL			6 INCHES TALL		
Size	Buttercream 4 mm	Fondant 4 mm	Whipped cream 4 mm	Buttercream 4 mm	Fondant 4 mm	Whipped cream 4 mm
4″	250 g	560 g	130 g	390 g	780 g	190 g
6″	450 g	920 g	230 g	670 g	1,250 g	340 g
8″	680 g	1,340 g	350 g	1,020 g	1,780 g	510 g
10″	960 g	1,810 g	480 g	1,440 g	2,370 g	730 g
12″	1,280 g	2,340 g	640 g	1,920 g	3,010 g	970 g
14″	1,640 g	2,930 g	820 g	2,470 g	3,710 g	1,240 g

READING IT PROPERLY

A square needs about a quarter more than a round of the same size, because it has more surface than the circle that fits inside it.

Fondant looks heavy, and it should. You roll a sheet far wider than the cake and trim most of it away, and that trim is counted here.

Four inches tall is counted as two layers and one joint of filling. Six inches is three layers and two joints. Torte your cake thinner and the filling goes up; add a layer and add one joint.

Whipped cream looks light because it is. Mostly air, under half a kilo a litre. Weigh 250 ml of your own and check, because every recipe whips differently.

Your thickness is probably not mine. Cover one real cake and weigh what left the bowl. That one weighing beats any chart.

Now, what does it cost you?

This chart gives you the grams. It cannot tell you what you paid for butter this month, what an hour in your own kitchen is worth, or which of the cakes you sell actually makes money. The Complete Cake Costing System works all of that out from your own prices and your own recipes, for any cake, in about a minute.

selar.com/cakecostingsystem

Created by **Iye Ibe Achem** · *Entrepreneur and Founder, BakeWealth International*
More free tools for bakers at **bakewealthinternational.com**